The Weight of Justice

Present Day —Amaravati

The city lights streaked past the windshield. Rain tapped softly against the glass.

Krishna drove.

Silent.

Focused—but distant. His hand still tense.

The recoil lingered—not from the gun, but from the decision.

Aryan was dead.

And for the first time, Krishna didn't know if justice had won… or if he had lost something deeper.

Beside him, Balaram said nothing.

The car stopped at the Intelligence Office. He stepped out, pausing just long enough to meet Krishna's eyes—firm, knowing.

Duty.

Then he walked inside.

Krishna stayed for a moment longer, alone in the silence.

Then he started the engine and drove ahead—toward his superiors… and the consequences waiting for him.

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Police Headquarters — Amaravati.

Krishna stood before the long teak conference table, facing a row of senior officers. The room was silent, but not calm. He reported the operation in precise, controlled sentences.

He finished.

A senior officer slammed a file on the table.

"The mission was to capture Aryan—not kill him. What happened out there?"

Krishna met his gaze without flinching. He had been asking himself that question since the shot.

Then it broke.

"Enough," a commanding voice rose.

A heavy silence followed.

The man at the head of the table, the Addl. DG, leaned forward. His gaze settled on Krishna.

"From this moment," the Addl. DG said, "Krishna will no longer lead this investigation alone."

"**Rudra…**"

He paused, letting the silence stretch.

"…will take command."

The name hit the room like a knife on marble. Someone whispered it—half awe, half fear.

"Rudra?" someone whispered.

"Yes," the Addl. DG confirmed.

"Sir, with due respect, Rudra's methods—" another officer began.

"—are exactly what we need now," the Addl. DG interrupted.

For the first time since the meeting began, Krishna's expression changed—not anger, not fear, but something deeper.

Krishna's fingers tightened behind his back.

Not in anger. Not in fear.

In recognition.

Because this wasn't the first time justice had slipped through his hands…

The first time… it had worn Rudra's face.

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2016 — Commissioner's Office, Vijayawada.

Rudra was never an officer people warmed to. He didn't chase applause or political favour; he cared about only one thing—*instant justice*.

He delivered it swiftly. Ruthlessly.

Somewhere along the way, he stopped caring how. His name became a whisper in every police corridor—a legend, the media called the ***Encounter Specialist***.

For the criminals on his list, he was a shadow that never missed. Justice, for him, wasn't a courtroom verdict—it was a bullet that never needed a second shot.

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It was monsoon season in Vijayawada.

The air smelled of wet earth and tension. The streets were soaked in rain, the sky heavy with clouds that never stopped rumbling.

Krishna and Arjun were just two young officers, fresh out of training, their gleaming badges still carrying the ideals of justice and law, serving under Rudra.

They admired him.

Feared him.

At one point, they even wanted to be like him —strong, unyielding, relentless.

But one incident changed everything.

A 14-year-old girl was found dead—raped and murdered—in her own home. It was the kind of crime that shook even seasoned officers.

Rudra put the young officers on point.

"Get the truth," Rudra said. "Whatever it takes."

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Victim's House, Currency Nagar — Vijayawada.

Arjun and Krishna entered carefully.

No crowd yet—only silence and rain against the windows. The room had been preserved.

The girl lay on the bed on her back.

Her head turned slightly toward the window.

Eyes half open.

Hair spread unevenly across the pillow.

Krishna didn't move immediately. He observed the entire room. The bedsheet was wrinkled, but not violently. No overturned furniture.

Arjun crouched near the bed, studying the creases.

No blood.

"If there was a fight," Arjun said, "the whole place would be a mess. But this is almost… controlled."

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Krishna's eyes moved slowly across the floor near the bed. Something faint caught the light.

A thin trail of white powder.

He crouched, bringing a small torch closer.

"Arjun," he said. "Look at this."

Arjun stepped beside him.

"Drugs?" he asked.

Krishna nodded slightly. "Possibly."

He carefully scraped a small sample into an evidence vial. They tagged and bagged the evidence.

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Krishna moved to the window. His eyes caught a smudge on the sill. It was a fingerprint.

"The window is clean except for this one spot," he said.

He swabbed the print carefully.

"Could be our guy."

"Let's check the back door too," Arjun said. "If he didn't come in through the front, maybe he slipped out the back."

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Arjun moved to the balcony exit—a back door leading to the narrow alley. The lock wasn't broken, but there was a faint scuff mark near the handle.

"If it wasn't forced, he had access," Krishna said, joining him. "Someone she trusted?"

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Krishna stood and glanced toward the living room where the girl's parents sat in stunned silence.

"We'll also need elimination samples," he said quietly.

Arjun nodded.

They collected fingerprints from the victim's parents and Naresh, the victim's brother, along with blood samples for DNA comparison—standard procedure to separate family traces from those left by the killer.

Arjun took Naresh's fingerprints, pressing his fingers one by one onto the ink pad and then onto the evidence sheet.

"Where were you that night?" Arjun asked casually.

Naresh avoided his eyes.

"With friends," he replied.

"Which friends?" Arjun asked.

Naresh hesitated for a moment before answering. "Just… some friends from college."

The room had been quiet.

Too quiet.

And when silence hides the truth… it usually knows the killer.

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Commissioner's Office — Vijayawada.

Back at the station, the evidence lay spread across the table, each piece quiet on its own, but together forming something neither of them wanted to name.

Krishna flipped through the reports without speaking. Arjun stood beside him, arms folded, watching the same pattern take shape from a different angle.

Nothing stood out. That was the problem.

A print from the window.

A trace from the floor.

A match where there shouldn't have been one. The lab notes were clinical, detached, but the conclusions they pointed toward were anything but.

Krishna closed the file. He didn't need to read it twice.

"Say it," Arjun said quietly.

"We already know."

The silence that followed… confirmed it.

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Victim's House, Currency Nagar — Vijayawada.

That evening, Krishna and Arjun visited Victim's House. Naresh sat on the couch, hands folded, posture controlled.

Only the details had shifted—the faint redness in his eyes, the tension in his fingers, the way he avoided looking directly at either of them.

"Where were you the night of your sister's death?" Krishna asked.

Naresh's eyes flickered—not with fear… but something else.

"I told you… I was at a friend's house."

But he maintained his composure until Arjun showed the photos and forensic reports.

"We found your fingerprints inside her room, your DNA in the semen sample from the postmortem, and blood traces on her clothes.

Your phone records put you at the scene. Your story doesn't add up."

Naresh's hands trembled. Sweat gathered along his temple.

Arjun placed the forensic report on the table.

"The powder we found in your sister's room matches the drug in your bloodstream," he said quietly.

"You were high that night, weren't you?"

Krishna pressed. “Did you see your sister that night? Tell us everything.”

Naresh’s eyes darted toward the door.

Arjun stepped forward. “We can do this the easy way—or the hard way.”

His voice faltered.

“She changed…”

“She wasn’t… mine anymore.”

He swallowed.

“I loved her… more than I should have.”

Silence.

Krishna didn’t move.

Arjun looked away.

They arrested the boy.

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Commissioner’s Office — Vijayawada.

Rudra didn’t ask questions.

“Reconstruct it,” Rudra said. “From the beginning.”

Naresh’s expression didn’t waver—unnervingly detached. His voice was cold, almost like a narrator recounting a distant event rather than a participant.

"She was already scared. She ran. I chased. And then"—he mimed raising his hand.

Rudra raised the gun.

For a brief moment—his finger paused on the trigger.

Not hesitating.

Deciding.

Krishna's mouth opened.

Arjun's jaw clenched.

Before a word escaped—the gunshot split the night.

The boy crumpled—gone before the words could leave his lips.

Krishna stepped forward—but it was already too late.

Rudra stood there, pistol still smoking, eyes locked on the lifeless body.

"You lost your right to finish that sentence the moment you pulled the trigger on her."

Krishna's jaw tightened.

"Why?" he shouted, his voice echoing across the deserted lot. "He deserved a trial!"

Rudra stood still, unshaken. "This is justice."

Arjun's fists curled tight at his sides.

"We don't get to choose who lives or dies!" he snapped. "That's not justice—it's vengeance!"

"Then call it vengeance," Rudra said evenly. "He killed his own sister. No courtroom can weigh that kind of sin."

He paused, eyes darkening.

"There are two kinds of cops in this world.

The ones who sleep.

And the ones who make sure others can."

Krishna's voice cracked under the weight of it all.

"And I chose not to become the monsters we're supposed to fight. You crossed the line."

That was the moment admiration turned into fear.

Before that, they had wanted to be like him. But that was before right and wrong began to blur.

They finally knew which side they stood on.

Krishna stood there, staring—not at the body, but at the line that had just been crossed.

And for the first time… he understood.

Rudra's justice… was indistinguishable from a crime.

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